DESIRE KALEBA

SENIOR FULL-STACK & AI ENGINEER

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Senior Full-Stack & AI Engineer with 6+ years building data-intensive SaaS, fintech, marketplace, and AI-enabled products. Lead engineer for a seven-person engineering team supporting a global data platform with millions of users and millions of API requests. Owns systems from architecture, API and data-model design through TypeScript and Next.js implementation, automated testing, cloud deployment, observability, and production operations. Applies coding agents, MCP integrations, custom skills, and structured human review to accelerate delivery without compromising engineering accountability.

CORE EXPERTISE

Full Stack: TypeScript, JavaScript, Node.js, React, Next.js, NestJS, Express, Go, Python
Data: PostgreSQL, MySQL, MongoDB, Redis, Prisma, SQL optimization, indexing, data modeling
Quality: Jest, Cypress, automated testing, code review, observability, production debugging
Architecture: REST, GraphQL, microservices, distributed systems, API design, system design, caching
Cloud: AWS, ECS, Lambda, RDS, S3, Docker, Kubernetes, Terraform, CI/CD, DigitalOcean
AI Engineering: OpenAI APIs, Claude, Codex, MCP workflows, agent systems, RAG, structured outputs

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

StartupBlink | Lead Full-Stack Engineer

Oct 2023 - Present | Remote

- Lead architecture and production delivery for a global startup-intelligence data platform serving millions of users and processing millions of API requests across customer-facing products and internal systems.
- Provide technical leadership to seven engineers across system design, implementation standards, code review, debugging, delivery planning, and production operations.
- Architect and maintain a large-scale TypeScript monorepo and Node.js services spanning APIs, relational data models, search, integrations, reusable React components, and cloud infrastructure.
- Modernized legacy JavaScript systems with TypeScript, React, and Next.js, contributing to a 35% increase in platform engagement while improving maintainability and development velocity.
- Improved CI/CD workflows supporting at least two production deployments per week, reducing deployment time by 50% and making releases more repeatable and reliable.
- Drive standards for automated testing, SQL and query optimization, caching, observability, and failure analysis across data-intensive production workflows.
- Introduced structured AI-assisted engineering using coding agents, MCP integrations, custom skills, and multi-agent workflows for implementation, refactoring, testing, debugging, and architecture analysis.

StartupBlink | Full-Stack Engineer

Oct 2022 - Sep 2023 | Remote

- Built and shipped production analytics, discovery, and data-platform capabilities using TypeScript, Node.js, React, Next.js, SQL, and cloud services.
- Designed APIs and data flows for large datasets, translated product requirements into maintainable systems, and resolved production issues across the full stack.

SELECTED PRODUCTS

PageVow | Founder and Lead Engineer

pagevow.com | AI SaaS

- Created and launched an AI-assisted platform for multilingual personal pages and digital experiences, acquiring 123 users, generating more than 600 pages, and receiving 79 customer requests with zero marketing.
- Generated the first $200 in organic revenue, validating real customer demand before paid acquisition or a formal marketing operation.
- Architected the product across Next.js, TypeScript, APIs, data persistence, media handling, analytics, QR sharing, RSVP workflows, payments, and production deployment.
- Designed structured AI-generation pipelines with validation and optional human review so unverified model output is not published directly.
- Own the complete product lifecycle, including architecture, UX, implementation, testing, deployment, production support, customer feedback, and commercial experimentation.

VelaBid | Founder and Lead Engineer

velabid.com | Marketplace

- Designed and built a collector-car marketplace supporting rich listings, timed auctions, bidding, watchlists, messaging, notifications, and transactional workflows.
- Engineered real-time auction behavior with server-side bid validation, soft-close anti-sniping extensions, and safeguards against conflicting or invalid bids.
- Designed relational models and state transitions for payments, escrow, auction settlement, notifications, and failure recovery using TypeScript, Next.js, Node.js, PostgreSQL, and Prisma.
- Own product strategy, system architecture, implementation, automated testing, deployment, and operational decisions from concept through public beta.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

Entendre Finance | Software Engineer

Sep 2022 - May 2023 | Remote

- Contributed to a large-scale institutional fintech and accounting platform at a high-growth company that was subsequently acquired.
- Designed serverless services and production integrations using AWS Lambda, Node.js, MongoDB, Solana, Arbitrum, and Optimism, with emphasis on financial correctness, auditability, and reliability.
- Built APIs and backend workflows for high-volume financial data and transaction processing while collaborating across engineering and product teams.

Side Hustle | Backend Engineering Mentor

Feb 2022 - Dec 2022 | Remote

- Mentored more than 1,800 developers in backend engineering and system design, translating architecture, debugging, and production tradeoffs into practical guidance.
- Reviewed technical work, explained API and database design, and helped developers progress from implementation exercises to maintainable backend systems.

Manaknight Digital | Senior Backend and Cloud Engineer

May 2021 - Jul 2022 | Remote

- Built backend services, APIs, and cloud-native integrations using Node.js, SQL, AWS, Docker, Terraform, and Ansible for international product teams.

FastoServices | Backend and Cloud Engineer

Oct 2019 - May 2021 | Remote

- Delivered e-commerce integrations and production services, strengthening deployment automation, system reliability, and maintainable API design.

Fulusi | Software Engineer

Aug 2019 - Oct 2019 | Kampala, Uganda

- Contributed to early-stage fintech product development, backend functionality, and data-driven customer workflows.

EDUCATION AND CERTIFICATIONS

BSc Computer Science | International University of East Africa
AWS Cloud Practitioner | Google Cloud | Advanced React Triplebyte Certified